

our lives suffer – such as personal relationships with friends or family, or missing work deadlines, or calling in sick, which might affect our professional lives.

SOCIALISING

When it comes to our social lives, so much of it is done through technology instead of directly with humans now. In fact, if you're not primarily socialising through social media and chat applications, you're one of the lucky ones, even if you feel like you're alienated from the rest of the world.

The obvious problem with technology assisted socialising is that it's not a good substitute. Everything important you do in life is done in person, whether that's at work or in your private life with loved ones, and living in the world taught us how to be better at that. However, we can use developed countries as a mirror of the future we're headed for, and we really should try not to make the same mistakes they did. With more and more of our socialising being done across the internet, we're slowly becoming loners. Now, this might actually be a good thing during a global pandemic, because people who are able to socialise online might fare better during lockdowns, but pandemics are a once in a lifetime or two kind of thing. More often than not, people are going to have to be able to actually socialise in order to get ahead in life, and social media is actually bad for that!

The anonymity of the internet and hiding behind keyboards give a lot of us a false sense of bravado and causes us to act in a manner that we just wouldn't in real life. For one thing, when talking to someone in person, they're actual humans, right there in front of you, who you can empathise with. Plus, face-to-face socialising puts into perspective who your friends really are, by letting you know who is actually making time for you, as opposed to someone online who might seem to care because they like your posts or say comforting things, but will never be there for you when you actually need them. In fact, as it turns out, even when we are meeting people in the real world,



Credit: Marc Smith

People "engaging" with their phones on the Seoul Metro

we're seldom making eye contact, because we're busy fidgeting with our phones, or glancing at them often. Even during video calls for work or catching up with friends and family, eye contact is impossible, because you would need to look directly at your web camera for the image displayed to look like you were looking directly at other people...

The biggest problem with social media, however, is the filter bubble pandemic that was here before COVID and will be here long after it is gone. While it's nice for people to be part of like-minded groups, centered around a favourite author, or TV series, or even a celebrity or game, or sports team, it's always benefited us to have to tolerate the views of people we don't like as well. Life online allows you to permanently mute anyone who doesn't think exactly like you at the tap of a button called "Block". The rise of internet trolling certainly makes the block button a necessity, but using it against anyone who disagrees with you is pretty much akin to sticking your fingers in your ears and yelling LA-LA-LA-LA-I-CAN'T-HEAR-YOU!

READING

Given that the world's richest man runs a company that started off selling books to people online, this might seem counter intuitive, but bear with us while we make our case.

To start with, the most obvious way in which modern technology has ruined books is to look at what people spend a majority of their time doing online. With all of the video content being consumed, who has time to read books anymore? And at this point we don't even care about the distinction between real books and e-books, we're just talking about reading dying out. While every single one of you reading this article is an exception to this new rule, it's a fact of life we cannot ignore.

Those of you aware of SEO guidelines will know how the internet went from the 3 minute reader to the 1 minute reader, the 20 second reader to now the 5 second reader. Attention spans are getting shorter, and people want all the possible information right up front and in their face, or else they bounce out of a site looking for someone else to spoonfeed them information. That's the reality of the internet, where 300 word news articles are now having to be cut down to a sentence or two in order for people to want to read them. More and more people just read a headline and think they know exactly what happened... and of course media houses are using clickbait headlines to try and get traffic, and all of this results in no one really sitting down and taking the time to read anything carefully anymore.

That's not the only problem when it comes to reading though, because